

MRINAL PANDE

Mrinal Pande was born in 1946. She is currently editor of *Saptahik Hindustan*, the Hindi edition of the leading newspaper *The Hindustan Times*, based in New Delhi. She has a distinguished career in journalism and the media, and has published several collections of short stories as well as plays and novels.

In the story, Baabu and Ma are the father and mother of the narrator, Naani is her grandmother, Maama is her mother's brother, Maami the Maama's wife, and Maasi is mother's sister. Bari and Chhoti are elder and younger respectively. The dai is the midwife or birth attendant who will attend on her mother.

The ritual referred to at the end of the story takes place on the Chaitya Shukla Ashtami day of the Hindu calendar, usually some time in March or April, when young girls (kanyakumari, virgin goddesses) are worshipped as the living incarnations of Devi, or the devine feminine principle. A roli spot or tikka of red powder is put on the girls' foreheads, the aarti ceremony is done by waving the sacred flame around their faces, and prasad, food given to the devotees after worship, is distributed to all the participating women.

'Girls' was first published in 1983 in *Dharmayug*, and in English translation in the same year in *Manushi* – a journal about women and society, New Delhi.

Girls

The day we left with Ma for Naani's house, Baabu broke a surahi. I don't know whether he did it on purpose or by accident, but anyway the floor was flooded with water. Ma held up her sari and called Saru's mother – who was trying to eavesdrop from the adjacent room – to mop up the water, because if someone were to slip and break their bones it would be yet another problem. To Ma, everything in life is a problem. As far as she is concerned, whether we are at home or at school, ill or just playing around, we are a problem. While mopping the floor, Saru's mother looked up at Ma and asked, 'This time you'll be away for at least three months, won't you?' Ma put her hands on her thighs as if she were assessing their weight, squatted down and said, 'Yes, they won't allow me to come back sooner.' She turned to me and ordered me to go out and play. I always seemed to turn up at the wrong time and at the wrong place. As I was leaving the room I managed to pick up a piece of the broken surahi which I enjoyed sucking, and I overheard Ma addressing either Saru's mother or the cobwebs hanging from the roof: 'I hope it's a boy this time. It will relieve me of the nuisance of going through another pregnancy.' I could just imagine Saru's mother, in her usual manner, shaking her head and saying, 'Why not? . . . why not?'

When we reached the station, I scrambled on to the train, fought my way through people and luggage and secured a place next to the window. Triumphant I stuck my tongue out at everyone and went 'Eee . . . Eee.' But when I noticed Ma's gaze turning towards me, I immediately started chanting the alphabet, 'E for Emli, E for Eekh.' Ma was not actually looking at me though, because she was preoccupied with all her problems. She had to mind the luggage, the wobbling surahi, the three of us, and cope with the exhaustion of pregnancy as well. At one of the stations we bought a lot of samosas filled with chillies. Just when we were buying them, a woman was making her

child pee through the next window. The sight made me feel quite nauseous and I couldn't eat my samosa, so I gave it to Ma instead. Meanwhile I crushed a piece of potato which was lying on the seat into the shape of an insect to frighten my younger sister. She screamed, Ma smacked me and I started to cry as well. My elder sister was irritated and said, 'Oh what a nuisance you are!' Despite her irritation, I know that it is only my elder sister who really loves me; everyone else is horrible.

Maama was waiting to receive us at the station. On the way to Naani's I sat next to Maami and noticed the rubies in her earlobes bobbing up and down while she chewed paan. Every time the driver pressed the jeep's horn, my sisters and I would scream in unison, 'Poo-poo'. The driver was amused at our screaming, and when we reached the house, he lifted me and my younger sister out of the jeep. He had a huge moustache, smelt of tea and bidis, and wore a uniform made of coarse wool which tickled me and made me feel sleepy. When the surahi was lifted out of the jeep it overturned, and once again there was water everywhere. This incident reminded me so much of Baabu that, absent-mindedly, I trod hard on my younger sister's sandal, nearly tripping her up. 'You are the cause of all my problems!' Ma hissed at me through tightly clenched teeth so that no one could hear. She then grabbed hold of my arm as if to prevent me from falling over but actually pressed it so hard that my shoulder hurt.

I thought of Baabu because whenever we came to Naani's house, he never accompanied us. And as soon as we arrived, Ma would be lost in the company of maasis, maamis, Naani and old maidservants. If we tried going near her during the day, someone or other would say, 'Let the poor thing have some rest at least while she is here.' Ma too would put on a pathetic act as if we always harassed her at home. I felt disgusted at the thought of entering Naani's house, so I deliberately loitered behind near the bushes. A mongrel dog came near and sniffed at me. Then I heard someone mentioning my name inside the house and saying, 'Now where has she disappeared?'

I entered the house along with the dog and saw Naani sitting with Maama's son on her lap. As soon as she saw the dog, she

shooed it away because to her all animals are as untouchables. The dog, used to being reprimanded, tucked its tail between its legs and went out. I was told to bend down and touch Naani's feet. Someone from the family said, 'Not like that . . . bend properly. You are born a girl and you will have to bend for the rest of your life, so you might as well learn/ Naani blessed me by waving her hand over my bowed back and said, 'This girl hasn't grown taller. Who would believe she is eight years old?'

Even though I pinched Maama's son, he kept following me around like an idiot. He was very fair, chubby and supposed to be cute. He was also tall for his age, and though only five years old could easily pass for seven. 'Will you tell me a story tonight?' he asked. I said no and pretended to read the newspaper.

'Oh what a nuisance this is,' Ma kept complaining. The old lady from the neighbourhood who had come to see Ma told Naani, 'This time Lali will definitely have a boy. Just look at her complexion - when she was expecting the girls it was pink, but now it has a tinge of yellow. I am sure it will be a boy this time.'

'Who knows, perhaps even this time . . .' moaned Ma as she put on a pathetic expression and began paring her nails.

'Is there anyone to cook for your husband?' asked the old lady. Her question set me thinking about Baabu, how good he smelt and the softness of his lap. And how when we came here Ma did not allow us to lie in her lap for too long and complained, 'Ugh! Oh! My bones are aching, my sari is all crushed. Get up now. I have such a lot of work to do, and to top it all there's this huge nuisance. Come on, get up.'

Naani folds her hands and prays: 'Oh goddess, protect my honour. At least this time let her take a son back from her parents' home.' At the end of the prayer she dries her tears with her pallav.

From the corner of my eyes I could see that my sisters were fast asleep. We were in a big room divided into two by a wooden partition. Right above my bed hung a big wall clock which was ticking away. Just before it struck the hour it made a hissing noise which was similar to my sister drawing in her breath just before howling. All the lights had been switched off and the room was flooded with moonlight. Tulsa dai was applying oil

to the soles of Ma's feet and saying, 'If it's a boy this time, I will demand a sari with stainless steel zari.' Even in the bright moonlight I could not see Ma's face, but only her huge stomach which looked like a drum. Ma's sari had slipped down and Tulsa dai while feeling her stomach touched a painful spot which made Ma moan just like a cow does when returning home from the fields.

'If I have a boy this time, then I will be relieved of this burden forever,' she tells Tulsa dai, and then adds, 'You can go home now, your children must be waiting for you. Be sure you put the oil vessel under the bed, otherwise one of these kids will kick it over in the morning and . . .' Ah, a bad omen. Whenever Ma left a sentence unfinished it seemed to loom in the air, like the ticking of the clock. I wonder why grown-ups always complete their sentences when they are talking about pleasant things, but always leave them unfinished if it's something unpleasant. Like, 'Ah, a woman's fate . . .', or 'Oh, three girls . . .' There's always a silence after these half-statements.

There's a bright star in the sky. Is that the Dhruva star? Baabu used to say that if I worked hard I could become anything I wanted, just as Dhruva became a star. 'But I can't become a boy, can I?' I once asked obstinately. I was surprised at Baabu's reaction when he put on a serious look and said sternly, 'Don't argue with your elders now.' I find it difficult to understand them. My elder sister says one should never trust grown-ups because if they want to know something they will prise it out of you by hook or by crook, but they themselves will never tell you a thing.

It's true, nobody ever tells us anything. In this place, it's when we go to sleep that the world of the elders awakens, opening like a magic casket. I want to stay awake and listen; I don't know why I fall asleep half-way through. I wonder whose voice it is now; it sounds as if someone is crying in suppressed tones. Is it Chhoti Maasi? 'I don't even get as much respect as a dog does in that house,' she tells Ma. I wonder where she is treated worse than a dog, then I hear Ma telling her, 'All of us suffer like that, one just has to endure it.' My eyes shut and I fall asleep.

The next morning, when everyone is having breakfast I ask

Ma what 'endure' means. I remind her by asking, what does Chhoti Maasi have to endure? I get one light slap, then another, but before Ma strikes me again Maami saves me and says, 'Let it be. She's only a child, after all.' 'She's no child, she's a witch,' says Ma as her stomach wobbles in anger. 'She's always listening on the sly to elders talking. Heaven knows what will become of her.'

When I go into the garden, my elder sister shakes the flowers she has gathered at me. 'Oh . . . you! I have told you a hundred times not to question grown-ups. If you keep on like this, one day these people will beat you so hard you will die.' 'I will ask questions. I will. I will,' I answer crying. 'Then go and die,' says my elder sister, and continues to thread a garland for Naani's Gopalji.

Naani stands by her and says loudly, 'You are my precious Lakshmi,' with the intention that I should hear.

In the afternoons I tell the younger children horror stories of ghosts and demons who lived in the walnut tree. I tell them that if they should wake up at twelve o'clock on a full-moon night they would see children being bathed in blood. They would also hear the ghosts speaking through their noses which at first is difficult to follow. The children follow me all over the house like mice following the Pied Piper.

Bari Maami and Ma give us money to buy sweet-sour golis just to get rid of us in the afternoon. Their room has been darkened by sticking green paper on the windows, and it is full of women - Ma, Maami, Maasis and Naani. They eat all the time and have cushiony arms, fat half-naked legs and wrinkled stomachs. Then why do they keep telling us not to sit with our legs spread out? 'You all look like cows,' I tell the women, but no one seems to have heard me. Chhoti Maasi, who is lying on the floor with a pillow under her head takes a sour goli from us, starts sucking it and says, 'Jijaji is really the limit.' Suddenly laughter explodes in the room. Who? Why? How? I look all around the room for an answer, but no one is bothered about us here, they are too lost in their own conversation. I leave the room and bang hard on the door from outside, wondering if Ma will call me a nuisance. No one comes out to reprimand me, though.

'Move aside,' says Hari's mother who is carrying a tray laden with glasses of tea into the room. 'Move. This is not for you, it's for the grown-ups. Move out of my way.' Hari's mother's nose is like a frog's and her eyebrows meet above her nose. Whenever she laughs, her cheeks hang loose like dead bats. 'Do move aside,' she says to me again. 'I won't,' I say, and try to block her way. 'I'll move only if you say girls are nice.' 'All right, all right, I have said it, so now move out of the way,' says Hari's mother. 'No,' I persist, 'say it properly.'

'Oh, Hari's ma, what's happening?' asks Maasi irritably from the room. 'Are you going to bring the tea next year, or what?' Hari's mother knits her thick eyebrows together and says, 'This Lali's middle daughter won't let me . . .' She starts laughing, and as she does so her frog-like nose bobs up and down. I can hear Ma naming me and saying, 'That girl must be harassing her. She was born only to plague my life.' Someone in the room advises her that she should not get angry in her condition.

For a long time I sit outside the house watching the birds flying and wishing that I had been born a bird. 'Do mother birds too think their girl birds are inferior?' I wonder. Then I hear a voice calling, 'Where has she gone?' and I know someone is searching for me. I hide behind the wall where no one can ever find me. I wish, I wish that somewhere, anywhere, I could find that magic betel nut which would make me invisible as soon as I put it in my mouth. What wonderful fun that would be.

In the evening, when Naani finishes her story, she says, 'Now off you go to sleep, all of you.' My younger sister has already fallen asleep and Hari's mother carries her away into our room. I ask Naani if I can sleep next to her. Naani's body is soft and warm and her quilt smells of cardamom and cloves. Besides, Naani keeps a torch under her pillow. If you take it with you to the bathroom after the lights are off, you don't knock your toes against anything. But Naani says, 'No, as it is this boy doesn't leave me. Where is the space on this bed for the two of you? Go and sleep next to your mother. I'll tell you another story tomorrow. All right?' Naani's tone becomes sugary in the way of most grown-ups when they want to coax you into doing something. In the other room, my elder sister asks with her

back turned to me, 'Did she let you sleep with her?' Her voice seems to be trembling with anger. Ma is snoring away. The clock ticks on. How can you sleep? Tick. Tick. Khrr. Khrr.

'Where are you? Girls?' calls Naani with a tray of crimson powder in her hands. In front of her there is a dish of halwa and a plate filled with puris. She has prepared those as offerings to the devi on Ashtami day. A mat has been spread in front of her for us to sit on. 'Come on girls, let me put the tikka on your foreheads.' She lights the camphor for aarti. 'Come now, let me do aarti to all of you.' My two sisters and Maama's beautiful daughters sit cross-legged in front of Naani. Naani puts a tikka on each forehead and then rings a bell. Exactly like the guard on the train. After the bell rings, she blows the conch. 'Poo-ooo.' I am suddenly transformed into a railway engine and race around the ledge of the courtyard. Inside, the room is filled with smells of camphor, halwa, ghee, and flowers. I shout, 'Come on, pay your fares to go to Calcutta. Poo-ooo.'

In the background I hear Naani saying, 'Come on dear, let me put the tikka on you. You are my kanyakumari, aren't you?'

'No,' I retort, 'I'm an engine.' Maama's son claps his hands with excitement and says, 'Oh, an engine, an engine.'

Suddenly I see Ma waddling towards me with a clenched fist and my stomach grows tight with fear. Her face is filled with rage. 'I'll make an engine out of you this very minute.'

The elderly neighbour intervenes, catches hold of Ma's hand and says, 'Have you gone mad, Lali?' She signals to me to obey, and adds, 'She is after all a child, a kanyakumari. Today is Ashtami, the devi's day; you mustn't hit a kanyakumari, it is a sin.'

I jump down from the ledge with a thud and see Naani serving the other girls halwa-puri with a tightly clenched mouth.

'Go on. Take the prasad from Naani. Why do you make your mother cry when she is in this condition?' Maasi asks me irritably.

'When you people don't love girls, why do you pretend to worship them?' My voice breaks into a sob and I feel so furious with myself that I want to swallow the burning camphor to choke my treacherous throat. I want to ask 'Why' again but

don't risk it because I am afraid I will start to cry. I don't want to cry in front of them.

Hari's mother puts her hand up to her cheek and says in wonder, 'Ma-ri-ma, just listen to her. What a temper for a girl to show!'

Naani is distributing a rupee and a quarter to each girl. She addresses the wall, 'You can buy twenty sour golis with this money' and holds out a twenty-five paisa coin wrapped in a rupee note towards me. I notice the mark of the crimson powder on the tip of her thumb, like a bloodstain.

I start moving back towards the wall and screaming 'I don't want all this halwa-puri, tikka or money. I don't want to be a goddess.' I scream so loudly that the pigeons pecking at the scattered grain in the courtyard take off in a flurry, as if a bullet had been fired somewhere.

*Translated from the Hindi
by Rama Baru*

LAKSHMI KANNAN

Lakshmi Kannan lives and works in New Delhi, and is a versatile and gifted bilingual writer. She writes her Tamil fiction under the name, Kaaveri. She has published one collection of short stories and a novel in Tamil. The collection *Rhythms* (1986) is her own translation of her short stories into English. Apart from other translations of leading Tamil writers, Lakshmi Kannan has published three collections of poems in English. She has also worked on the Tamil-English section of a lexicon in fourteen Indian languages, a project undertaken by the National Council of Education, Calcutta.

'Rhythms' is an intensely localised story, set in the Kapaleswar Temple complex of Mylapore, in one of the oldest parts of Madras, and it draws upon shared experiences of sound, smell and taste. The narrator follows the prescribed order of worship, making her offerings first to Ganesha, the elephant headed son of Shiva and Parvati, then to Muruga, eldest son of Shiva, then to Devi, the great goddess, finally entering Shiva's shrine.

The sculpture at the back of the temple, which the pious widows are anxious to explain, are of the Arubathimooavar – the sixty-three canonised saints – and the Navagriha, the nine planets of Hindu astronomy.

The musical scale that the author refers to, sa ri ga ma pa da ni sa, roughly equates to c d e f g a b c.